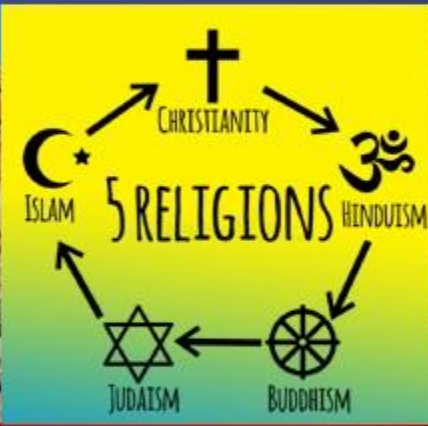


ART & CULTURE



INDIAN DANCE

MODULE - 1

**CLASSICAL DANCE
FORMS**

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

EVOLUTION OF "DANCE"



- 1 Dance in India has a rich and vital tradition dating back to ancient times
- 2 Excavations, inscriptions, chronicles, genealogies of kings and artists, literary sources, sculpture and painting of different periods provide extensive evidence on dance.
- 3 Myths and legends also support the view that dance had a significant place in the religious and social life of the Indian people.
- 4 However, it is not easy to trace the precise history and evolution of the various dances known as the 'art' or 'classical' forms popular today.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

EVOLUTION OF "DANCE"

- 5 In literature, the first references come from the Vedas where dance and music have their roots.



- 6 A more consistent history of dance can be reconstructed from the epics, the several Puranas and the rich body of dramatic and poetic literature known as the **nataka** and the **kavya** in Sanskrit.
- 7 A related development was the evolution of classical Sanskrit drama which was an **amalgam** of the spoken word, gestures and mime, choreography, stylised movement and music.
- 8 From 12th century to 19th century there were many regional forms called the musical play or **sangeet-nataka**.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

EVOLUTION OF "DANCE"

- 9** Contemporary classical dance forms are known to have evolved out of these musical plays.



- 10** From Shiva's tandava dance, which signifies the cycle of creation, preservation and destruction, to the feminine response of Parvathi, Indian mythology is replete with examples of dance forms and expressions.

- 11** Similarly, the engravings of community dancing at Bhimbetka and the sculpture of the Bronze dancing girl of the Harappan civilisation highlights the importance of dance as a means of social entertainment.



12 The earliest treatise on dance available to us is Bharata Muni's Natyashastra, the source book of the art of drama, dance and music.

13 It is generally accepted that the date of the work is between the 2nd century B.C.E- 2nd century C.E.

14 The Natyashastra is also known as the "Fifth Veda".

15 According to the author, he has evolved this Veda by taking words from the Rig Veda, music from the Sama Veda, gestures from the Yajur Veda and emotions from the Atharva Veda.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

EVOLUTION OF "DANCE"

- 16** There is also a legend as given in Bharatha's Natya Shastra, where as a pastime for Gods, Lord Brahma himself wrote the Natya veda, which has over 36,000 verses.



- 17** In terms of the classical tradition formulated in the Natyashastra, dance and music are an inextricable part of drama.

- 18** In this context, Natya is an amalgamation of dance, drama and music and included *Pathya* (words) from Rig Veda, *Abhinaya* (gestures) from Yajur Veda, *Geet* (music) from Sama Veda and *Ras* (emotions) from Atharva Veda.

- 19** The art of natya carries in it all these constituents and the actor is himself the dancer, the singer, and the performer combining all the three functions.



20 As per *Abhinaya Darpan*, Nandikeshwara's famous treatise on dance, dance is considered as having three aspects: *Natya*, *Nritya* and *Nritta*.

- *Natya* highlights the **dramatic element** and most dance forms do not give emphasis to this aspect today with the exception of dance-drama forms like Kathakali.
- *Nritya* is essentially **expressional**, performed specifically to convey the meaning of a theme or idea.
- *Nritta* on the other hand, is **pure dance** where body movements do not express any mood (bhava), nor do they convey any meaning.



Nritta



Nritya



Natya

**Navarasas**

21 To present nritya and natya effectively, a dancer should be trained to communicate the navarasas.

22 These are: love (shringaara), mirth/amusement (haasya), compassion (karuna), valour(veera), anger (raudra), fear (bhayanak), disgust (bibhatsa), wonder (adbhuta) and peace (shaanta).

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

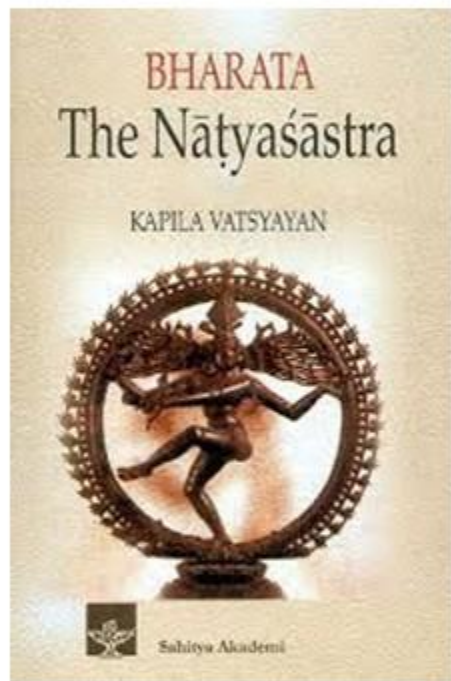
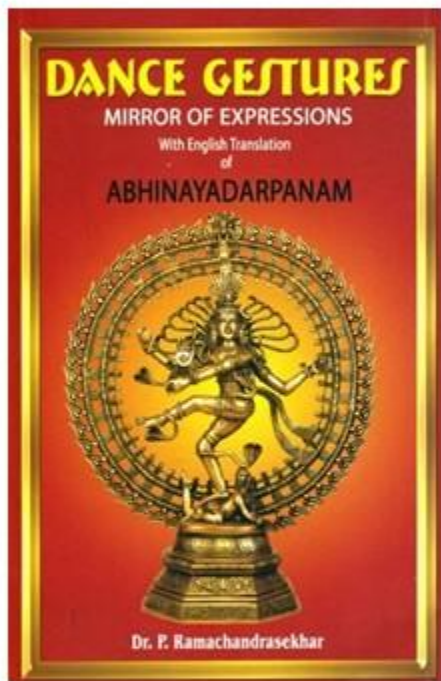
EVOLUTION OF "DANCE"

23 An ancient classification followed in Bharata's Natya Shastra is that there are two basic aspects to all styles of Indian classical dance: *Tandava* and *Lasya*.

- Tandava the masculine is heroic, bold and vigorous.
- Lasya the feminine is soft, lyrical and graceful.



Lasya and Tandava aspect of dance



Bharata and Nandikesvara, the main authorities conceive of dance as an art which uses the human body as a vehicle of expression.

- 24** This is achieved through *angika*, the body and limbs, *vachika*, the song and speech and *aharya*, costume and adornment; and *satvika*, moods and emotions.
- 25** Two further aspects of natya are the modes of presentation and the style.
- 26** There are two modes of presentation, namely the *Natyadharmi*, which is the formalised presentation of theatre, and the *Lokadharmi* sometimes translated as folk, realistic, naturalistic or regional.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

EVOLUTION OF "DANCE"

- 27** Nurtured for centuries, dance in India has evolved in different parts of the country its own distinct style taking on the culture of that particular region, each acquiring its own flavour.

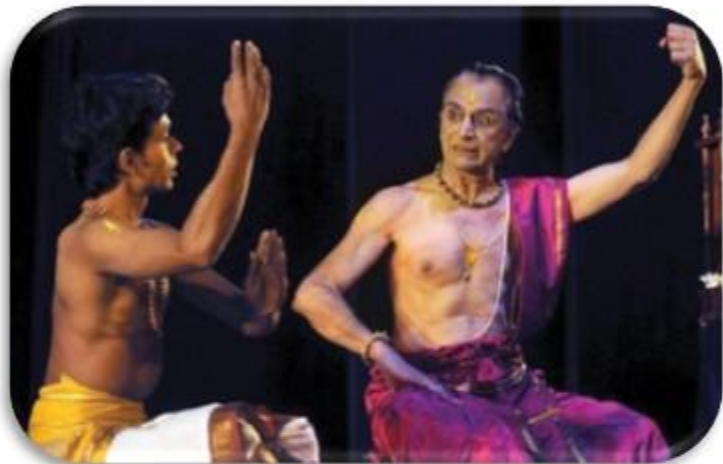


- 28** Consequently a number of major styles of 'art' dance are known to us today, like Bharatnatyam, Kathakali, Kuchipudi, Kathak, Manipuri, Odissi and Sattriya.

- 29** Then, there are regional variations, the dances of rural and tribal areas, which range from **simple, joyous celebrations of the seasons, harvest or birth of a child** to dances for the propitiation of demons or for invoking spirits.

- 30** Today there is also a whole new body of modern experimental dance.

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS



Guru Shisya Parampara

- 1 Distinct styles of dance have evolved in the different regions of India, each with their own specific nuances.
- 2 However, all these dance forms are governed by the basic rules and guidelines laid down in the Natya Shastra, the principal rule being that true transfer of knowledge can only come through a guru.
- 3 The guru passes on the knowledge of the different traditions – sampradaayas – onto the disciple.
- 4 This '*guru-shisya parampara*' forms the basic core of Indian classical art form.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

1 BHARATANATYAM



- 1 Oldest among all classical dance forms, Bharatanatyam derives its name from Bharata Muni and 'natyam' which means dance in Tamil.
- 2 However, other scholars have ascribed the name 'Bharata' to 'Bhava' and 'Taal'.
- 3 The origins of this dance form can be traced back to 'Sadir' – the solo dance performance of the temple dancers or 'devadasis' in Tamil Nadu, hence it was also referred to as 'Dashiattam'.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

1 BHARATANATYAM



E. Krishna Iyer

- 4 With the decline of the Devadasi system, the art too became nearly extinct.
- 5 However, the efforts of E. Krishna Iyer, a prominent freedom fighter, revived this dance form.
- 6 Previously, this dance form was the monopoly of solo female dancers; it has since become increasingly popular among male and group artists as well.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

1 BHARATANATYAM

- 7** **Rukmini Devi Arundale**, another famous proponent of Bharatnatyam, is responsible for giving global recognition to the dance.



Rukmini Devi Arundale

RUKMINI DEVI ARUNDALE

- One of the most important revivalist in the Indian classical dance form of Bharatanatyam from its original 'sadir' style, prevalent amongst Devadasis.
- An Indian theosophist influenced by the thoughts of Annie Besant and got married to George Arundale, the most trusted associate of Annie Besant.
- Founder of Kalakshetra Foundation
- The Animal Welfare Board of India was started under the stewardship of Late Smt. Rukmini Devi Arundale.

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

1 BHARATANATYAM



- 8 In the early nineteenth century, four dance teachers of Thanjavur defined the elements of a Bharatnatyam recital.
- 9 The four Thanjavur teachers, known as the ***"Tanjore Quartet"*** are ***Chinnayya, Ponniah, Vadivelu and Shivanandam***. Under them, Bharatnatyam also came to be known as **Thanjavur natyam**.
- 10 They, under the patronage of **Raja Serfoji**, are said to have been responsible for the repertoire of Bharatnatyam dance as we see it today.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

1 BHARATANATYAM



**Padma
Subramanian**



Mrinalini Sarabhai

- 11** In this dance form, equal emphasis is given on both the Tandava and Lasya aspects of dance, with major emphasis on “Mudras”.
- 12** In a Bharatnatyam recital, the knees are mostly bent and the weight is equally distributed across both the feet.
- 13** It is also characterised by the “**Ekaharya lasyam**” style in which one dancer plays many different roles.
- 14** Some famous proponents: Yamini Krishnamurthy, Padma Subramanian, Mrinalini Sarabhai, Mallika Sarabhai, etc.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

1 BHARATANATYAM

SOME FEATURES OF BHARATANATYAM DANCE

- 1** Alarippu – It is an invocatory piece of performance which includes basic dance postures and is accompanied with rhythmic syllables. It is meant to seek the blessings of God.
- 2** Jatiswaram – It is the pure form of dance, including the different poses and movements.
- 3** Shabdham – It is the dramatic element, which includes the abhinaya in the song. It is generally in praise of the glory of the God.
- 4** Varnam- This is a combination of dance and emotions, synchronized with taal and raga.
- 5** Padam- It refers to a solemn spiritual message of the abhinaya expressed by the artist.
- 6** Jawali- These are short love-lyrics performed at a faster tempo.
- 7** Thillana- It is the concluding stage of the performance and comprises pure dance with exuberant movement and intricate rhythmic variations.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

2

KUCHIPUDI



- 1 Originally performed by group of actors going from village to village, known as Kusselavas, Kuchipudi derives its name from the Andhra village of Kusselavappuri or Kuchelapuram.
- 2 With the advent of Vaishnavism, the dance form became a monopoly of the male Brahmins and began to be performed at temples.
- 3 Stories of Bhagavat Purana became a central theme of the recitals, and the dancers came to be known as **Bhagavathalus**.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

2

KUCHIPUDI



Balasaraswathi

- 4 The dance form gained prominence under the **patronage of the Vijayanagar and Golconda rulers.**
- 5 However, it remained confined to village and remained obscure till the advent of twentieth century, when Balasaraswati and Ragini Devi revived this dance form. The traditional male preserve became popular with female dancers as well.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

2 KUCHIPUDI

SOME FEATURES OF KUCHIPUDI DANCE

- 1 Most of the Kuchipudi recitals are based on stories of Bhagwata Purana. There is a predominance of Shringaar ras.
- 2 Each principal character introduces itself on the stage with a “Daaru”, which is a small composition of dance and song, specifically choreographed for the revelation of each character.
- 3 The Kuchipudi dance style is a manifestation of the earthly elements in the human body.
- 4 In a Kuchipudi recital, the dancer may combine the role of a singer into himself/ herself as well. Hence, in a way it becomes a drance-drama performance.
- 5 Both Lasya and Tandava elements are important in the Kuchipudi dance form.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

2 KUCHIPUDI

SOME FEATURES OF KUCHIPUDI DANCE



*Kuchipudi dancer performing
a tarangam*

- 6 Apart from group performances, there are some popular solo elements in Kuchipudi as well. Some of them are:
- **Manduk Shabdam**- Tells the story of a frog.
 - **Tarangam**- The dancer performs with his/her feet on the edges of a brass plate and balancing a pot of water on the head or a set of diyas.
 - **Jala Chitra Nrityam**- In this item, the dancer draws pictures on the floor with his or her toes while dancing.

INDIAN DANCE FORMS

INDIAN CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS

2

KUCHIPUDI

SOME FEATURES OF KUCHIPUDI DANCE



Radha Reddy and Raja Reddy

7

A Kuchipudi recital is generally accompanied with Carnatic music- Violin and Mridgangam being the principal instruments.

8

Famous Proponents: Radha Reddy and Raja Reddy, Yamini Krishnamurthy, etc.

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